

Observers say the expansion of BRICS has happened largely in the wake of G7 aggression and economic sanctions slapped on the countries it sees as errant. In the recent past, countries such as Iran (2012), North Korea (2017), and Russia (2022) have been expelled from SWIFT and barred from transacting in dollar, thus crippling their access to financial resources, investments and trade with other countries.

“Economic sanctions don’t simply penalise the countries in question. They inconvenience their partners, too,” says Mukherjee. A case in point is the Russian oil that India had to pay for in dirhams and yuan in the past after Russia ran up a massive pile of

rupees it had no use for. The rupee-ruble payment mechanism the duo devised subsequently to circumvent the sanctions has the US up in arms again. Trump has threatened a 50% tariff on India because of its oil and defence imports from Russia. On August 14, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent further warned that if Trump’s proposed meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Alaska didn’t go well, even higher secondary tariffs could be imposed on India.

Arguing that BRICS is yet to find a cohesive identity of its own, trade expert and former professor of economics at Jawaharlal Nehru University Biswajit Dhar, says that

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WHY BRICS

Core Members

Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, UAE, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia and Iran

48.5%
of the world's population

Approximately
72% of the globe's reserves of rare earth minerals

43.6%
of the global oil production

36% of the world's natural gas production

78.2%
of the global production of mineral coal

39%
of global GDP @ PPP in 2023

24% of total global trade

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